

FINAL PROJECT

Expository Writing

From Character to Game: Writing, Design Thinking, and AI Collaboration

WHAT THIS PROJECT IS ABOUT

You designed a character in Assignment 3. This project asks what happens when four individually designed characters are placed into the same system together.

Working in groups of four, you will use NotebookLM as a collaborative thinking partner to read your characters as a system, design a game that only these four characters could produce, write and test the rules that make it playable, and generate a set of outputs that present the game to someone who was not part of building it.

Writing is what drives this project. The creative decisions you made in A3, how you described your character's contradiction, their strength, their pivotal moment are the raw material everything else is built from. This project asks you to take that writing further, into a system, into rules, into outputs that make your character playable.

Writing also shapes how you work with AI here. NotebookLM reads what you give it. The quality of what it surfaces, the accuracy of what it generates, and the usefulness of what it checks, all of it depends on how precisely you wrote your characters, your rules, and your prompts. AI does not compensate for unclear writing. It amplifies it in both directions.

Across four phases you will develop:

- **Systems thinking** reading four characters not as individuals but as a combination, identifying what the system contains, what it exposes, and what it makes possible
- **Critical thinking:** questioning NotebookLM's outputs, defending or adjusting your design decisions with specific reasoning, and testing whether your logic actually holds
- **AI literacy:** using NotebookLM as a purposeful collaborative partner, understanding what it can and cannot do with your sources, and correcting it where it gets your characters wrong
- **Collaborative design:** moving between individual thinking and group decision-making, negotiating contributions, and producing something none of you could have built alone
- **Descriptive writing applied:** everything you built in A3 is the foundation. The stronger and more specific your writing, the richer your game will be, and the more useful your AI collaboration becomes

HOW THE PROJECT WORKS

The project runs across four phases. Each phase produces a worksheet that becomes a source in your shared NotebookLM notebook. Each phase builds directly on what came before, vague

thinking in Phase 2 causes problems in Phase 3, and weak rules in Phase 3 produce weak outputs in Phase 4.

NotebookLM is your shared workspace. Every group member works in the same notebook. Add your instructor and TA as collaborators before Phase 1 begins.

PHASE BY PHASE

Before Phase 1 — Set Up Your Notebook

- Create a shared NotebookLM notebook
 - Upload all four A3 character worksheets as sources 1 through 4
 - Add your instructor and TA as collaborators
 - Sources in notebook: 1, 2, 3, 4 — four A3 worksheets
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Phase 1: Game Discovery

What it is: Using NotebookLM to read all four characters as a system and discover what kind of game they make possible.

- Build a comparative profile of all four characters using NotebookLM
 - Analyze the system — what it contains, what it exposes, what only each character contributes
 - Each student writes an individual designer statement about their own character
 - Upload completed Phase 1 worksheet to NotebookLM
 - Sources in notebook after this phase: 1-4 (A3 worksheets) + 5 (Phase 1 worksheet)
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Phase 2: Game Design

What it is: Turning the system analysis from Phase 1 into a designed game with a type, mechanic, end condition, and character contributions.

- Explore and decide on game type as a group, without NotebookLM first, then query to test the logic
- Define the end condition, what these four characters make inevitable
- Each student designs their own character's contribution individually, then the group synthesizes
- Design the mechanic and review it with NotebookLM
- Upload completed Phase 2 worksheet to NotebookLM

- Sources in notebook after this phase: 1-5 + 6 (Phase 2 worksheet)

Phase 3: Game Rules and Logic *What it is:* Translating the design decisions from Phase 2 into a precise ruleset, then testing whether the logic holds.

- Write the full rules document: setup, turn structure, contributions, resolution, end condition, winning conditions
- Each student identifies their character's pressure point, the moment the rules force their A3 contradiction to surface
- Run individual and group logic checks using NotebookLM to find gaps and contradictions
- Document what you are adjusting before Phase 4
- Upload completed Phase 3 worksheet to NotebookLM
- Sources in notebook after this phase: 1-6 + 7 (Phase 3 worksheet)

Phase 4: Production *What it is:* Using all seven sources in your notebook to produce a set of outputs that present the game to someone who was not part of building it.

- Generate one infographic per character in NotebookLM Studio, each student reviews and corrects their own
- Generate an Audio Overview that introduces the game
- Generate a Video Overview that shows how the game is played
- Produce prototype visuals using any AI image generation tool
- Write a group reflection on NotebookLM as a collaborative partner across all four phases
- No new upload, Phase 4 draws from all seven sources already in the notebook

PROJECT ROADMAP

Phase	What you do	NotebookLM sources	Work mode
Before Phase 1: Set up notebook	Upload all 4 A3 worksheets. Create shared notebook. Add instructor and TA as collaborators.	Sources 1–4: four A3 character worksheets	Individual — each student uploads their own A3

Phase	What you do	NotebookLM sources	Work mode
Phase 1: Game discovery Upload as source 5	Build character profiles (A1). Analyze system assets and gaps (A2). Write designer statements (A3) — own character only.	After: sources 1–4 + Phase 1 worksheet = 5 sources	Mixed — A1 and A2 group, A3 individual
Phase 2 : Game design Upload as source 6	Choose game type (B1). Define end condition (B2). Design contributions and synthesize (B3). Design and review mechanic (B4).	After: sources 1–5 + Phase 2 worksheet = 6 sources	Mixed — B3.1 individual, rest group
Phase 3: Rules and logic Upload as source 7	Write full rules document (C1). Identify pressure points — use A3 worksheet not NotebookLM (C2). Logic check per character (C3.1). Group interaction check (C3.2–3.3).	After: sources 1–6 + Phase 3 worksheet = 7 sources	Mixed: C2 individual, C3 group
Phase 4: Production No new upload	Generate infographics, one per character (D1). Generate audio overview (D2). Generate video overview (D3). Produce prototype visuals (D4). Group reflection on AI collaboration (D5).	All 7 sources. Share public notebook link at end of D5.	Mixed — D1 individual, D2–D5 group
Submit	One combined PDF of all four phase worksheets in order. Visuals PDF — all D4 prototype images. Public NotebookLM link — instructor and TA already added as collaborators.	—	—

WHAT TO SUBMIT

Submit the following as a single combined submission:

- **One combined PDF** — all four phase worksheets merged into a single file, in order
- **Visuals PDF** — all prototype images from D4 compiled in one file
- **Public NotebookLM link** — shared at the end of Phase 4. Your instructor and TA must already be added as collaborators